

Usability Study | Create a Case

Remote
May 2020

Study Information

Participants

- 15 participants tested
 - 3 mobile (2 phones 1 tablet)
 - 1 safari
 - 2 chrome
 - 12 desktop/laptop
 - 9 users tested in Chrome
 - 1 in Firefox
 - 2 in Edge
- Age range
 - 9 (18-39)
 - 7 (40-65)
- None of the participants had filed with court before
- 1 participant had seen the file a case site
- 4 participants were court employees

Findings | Comprehensive Findings

Key Findings

Form instructions are not directive and authoritative enough.

- Users want step-by-step directions (not explanations) of exactly what is required of them.

* (Seen also in Usability Studies from October 2019 and January 2019)

Majority of users continue to experience significant confusion and frustration about the PDF forms.

- Users still have trouble understanding what to do with all of the PDF forms, and **why they are repeating information in a PDF and in the online form.**
- Users are not merging the IRS Notice and their Petition form.
- Users do not notice or fully understand redaction instructions.

* (Seen also in Usability Studies from October 2019 and January 2019)

Key Findings

Users are confused about how the filing fee fits into the process

- Expect to pay as part of the process, most often before submission of the form
- Users don't know what will happen if they don't pay the filing fee

* (Seen also in Usability Studies from October 2019)

Users don't know what to do after submitting the Petition

- Next steps are still unclear (when / how will they hear from the Court, are they “done”)

Users can't complete the Petition process with only a mobile phone.

- The process of downloading the PDF forms, completing the form, and uploading a completed copy is a barrier for mobile users.
- The linked PDF forms are not fillable PDFs on mobile, and users have no way to complete the forms without using a second device, or downloading another app or extension.
- File structures on mobile devices are prohibitive to users being able to download and upload forms easily

On login to the dashboard, does the user have any doubts about what they need to do to proceed with the petition and other associated documents?

“What do i do next?”

Insight / Themes

- When landing on the dashboard for the first time, users are still not clear exactly what steps they need to take to begin the process.
- The call-to-action is weak and the instructions are not giving users strong confidence that they are prepared to begin the process.
- Legal language and terminology is still confusing, but doesn't seem to be a barrier to completing the process.

Does the user understand that there is a filing fee? Does the user know what payment options they have?

“There’s nowhere telling me how to pay if i want to go from here”

Insight / Themes

- Users understand that there is a filing fee for the Petition.
- Users expect the filing fee to be required as part of submitting the Petition, and do not expect or necessarily trust paying the fee as a separate piece of the process.
- Users are unclear of the consequences of not paying the fee, or how it will impact their case.

Are users able to understand what forms to complete for each document, and how and where to upload those documents?

“Don’t like it when there’s a form I have to open up, fill in and then upload. It would be nice if I could do it all in the online form.”

Insights/ Themes

- Users are not fully reading the form instructions.
- Users have questions around which forms are actually required, and expect **more explicit step-by-step instructions** on what they need to do.
- Users are generally able to locate and view the forms presented in the Dashboard and Tips screen instructions.

Does the user understand when to redact their PII, and when to include it (STIN)?

“Well, don't ask for the STIN to begin with”

Insights/ Themes

- Users (generally) are not acknowledging the redaction statements
- Users that did acknowledge these instructions did not fully understand why they would have to do this, and what happens if they don't redact their information before uploading documents

Can the user easily complete the form wizard?

“That’s good to have” (regarding error messaging for required fields)

Insights/ Themes

- Users are able to complete the form wizard and start a case*
- Some users had difficulty identifying required fields vs. optional fields, but were still able to successfully complete the form due to proper error handling.
- Form components work as expected, with some users commenting on ideal functionality (jump-to ability for trial location field, copy address checkbox automatically unchecking after edits are made)

* Mobile users could complete the data entry portion of the form wizard without issue; pdf uploads prevented some mobile users from being able to complete the form.

Does the user understand that they need to merge the Petition and IRS Notice into a single PDF? Do they know how to accomplish this?

Insights/ Themes

- Users frequently miss or do not understand the instructions to merge the IRS Notice and Petition into one PDF (only 4 of 15 participants commented on these instructions).
- Mobile users have no easy way to complete this task using only a mobile device.

How confident are users to submit their completed form to the Court?

Insights/ Themes

- Users are comforted by the information that is displayed on the Review Screen, and are fairly confident to submit the form to the Tax Court.
- Some language and numbering conventions (reminders) are confusing or incongruent with other language in the instructions.
- Users like the progress bar as an indicator that the form is being submitted.
- Users are not completely confident if the form can be submitted if all requirements or rules are not followed (fee payment, timeliness check).
- Users have no context for the service email and do not understand what it means.

What are user expectations after they submit the petition?
Do they understand what will happen next?

“When am I gonna hear something?”

Insights/ Themes

- Users don't completely understand what their next steps are after submitting the Petition.
- Users expect to be required to pay the filing fee as part of the Petition process, or at minimum, to be prompted to immediately pay after submission.
- Users expect to receive an email confirmation when the Petition is successfully filed.
- Users are not carefully reading the Confirmation screen, and do not fully understand the language provided (docket number, etc.).
- User (one) did not understand that additional documents could be submitted online after the Petition.

Recommendations

★ Implement online form for the entire process

We've already proven that users can complete the form wizard. At this point it will take less time to implement a completely online form than applying band aids that we know are not effective.

- Will allow users to complete the process using a mobile phone
- Will alleviate user confusion about PDF requirements
- Will eliminate instructions around form requirements and redaction
- Will increase user adoption by making the process easier and less overwhelming
- More cohesive process (reduce entry of duplicate information, add more guidance for filing fee)

What does this involve?

Implement updated UI

- Create a fully online version of required forms (Petition, ODS)
- Reconsider how to capture STIN information
- Avoid any required uploads to ensure the form is mobile-friendly
- Allow users to save a draft Petition and submit at a later time (post-MVP)

Level of effort to implement

- We already have entities set up to do everything we want to do here

Other considerations

- Allow other formats for IRS notice upload (jpeg, etc.) so mobile users can still include their IRS notice
- We can generate a PDF of the information entered in the online Petition form if a document is still needed
- Digital signatures

What led us here?

We've been putting band aids on known issues in order to stay within the current framework

- Previous approach has been to better explain a complicated process as opposed to simplifying the process - we now want to solve the root problem
- Keep hearing the same issues each round of testing

We've tried everything except what we know will solve the problem

- Disconnection remains between the users mental model and what we are asking them to do
 - Even after they read and comprehend instructions, users are confused about how to actually do what we've instructed them to do

This is part of our agile process

- When what we've been trying isn't working, we try something else
- Example: Redesign of messaging flow - break it to make it better
- The lift is not as high as we think; we're already halfway there with the current form wizard
- Benefit outweighs the cost

What are the risks of keeping the current process?

User adoption and optics

- Petitioners will not use the online filing system, jeopardizing the overall success of the project
- Public users are going to be less forgiving than internal users
- People with only a mobile phone **CAN'T** use it, leaving out key demographics of the user population

Resource / time

- Continued wasted time putting band aids on the problem

Launch logistics

- Increased help desk calls due to user confusion during the e-filing process
- Petitions clerks will have to continue entering in paper petitions while correcting erroneous e-filings

Recommendations

Other design recommendations

- “My cases” navigation button change to “Home”
- “Start a Case” button needs to be in a more prominent location. Move to top of page so it doesn’t get lost
- Add filing fee sidebar to confirmation screen
- Add more information on what to do next including more info on filing fee, users need to know why filing fee is important and how it will affect their case if not paid
- Change button “back to dashboard” to “Back to Home”

Questions | Come on, let us have 'em!

Appendix

On login to the dashboard, does the user have any doubts about what they need to do to proceed with the petition and other associated documents?

Dashboard: First Impressions

- Should i start with the forms or hit start a case - doesn't know where to begin
- Initial page is not clear what really needs to be done - what order
- Scary process- would like to see more information related to what a user may be feeling during this process
- Wants to see headers as questions
- Definitions of terms (business, partnership) would be helpful
- Dashboard - no clue what to do
- Wants more more definite instructions
- What do i do next?

Dashboard : Call to Action

- Not sure if starting a case is the same as filing petition
- Doesn't like having to scroll; Start a Case button needs to be larger, higher on page,
- Start a Case button not obvious- expects to see how to start a case and didn't notice it until she scrolled
- Start a case - was hung up because of the bullet beforehand - login to this portal ; Start a case?? Hesitant at first but starts a case; Is that what the button is? Or does that refer to the current page (dashboard)
- 3 steps but doesn't see the prime time - what you came here to do until you scroll - would expect to see the start a case button more clearly

Does the user understand that there is a filing fee? Does the user know what payment options they have?

Dashboard/ Filing Fee:

- Filing fee Options- didn't see this at first - kind of buried
- Takes a minute but sees the Filing Fee; Not clear what happens if she doesn't pay the fee
- Sees the payment information but didn't really know what to do with it
- filing fee instructions] Would like to see both on the confirmation page and on dashboard
- Looks at other options - would prefer not to hide the mailing options in the accordion - some people don't like using CC online and may not click to see more options

Step 5 - Review Your Petition / Filing Fee - Instructions:

- "Where's my payment thing?"

Case Confirmation / Filing Fee - Instructions:

- Sees filing fee info there
- There's nowhere telling me how to pay if i want to go from here- would have thought i would have to pay first; Docket number- will be used to identify your case and to make payment ; Not obvious that the docket number is needed to make payment ; Back to Dashboard button makes it look like "it's over"
- Remembers there is a fee from the dashboard - obviously you don't have to pay to submit the form; Doesn't know what will happen if she doesn't pay the fee, time frame to pay it, what happens if she doesn't pay

Does the user understand that there is a filing fee? Does the user know what payment options they have? Continued

Case Confirmation / Filing Fee - Instructions:

- Sees remember to pay info; If there's a way to pay right now, he would probably do it
- Once he pays the fee "My petition is filed and complete"
- Doesn't see the waiver option - clicks that to open; Next step for her would be to fill out the waiver; She expects to have to mail the application - doesn't understand that she could file this document online through the CMS
- Pay filing fee/waiver options would like on this

Case Detail / Filing Fee - Instructions:

- Sees filing fee not paid and doesn't remember having to pay a filing fee, and didn't notice it on the dashboard

Dashboard / Next Steps:

- Takes a minute but sees the Filing Fee; Not clear what happens if she doesn't pay the fee
- Sees the payment information but didn't really know what to do with it
- [filing fee instructions]Would like to see both on the confirmation page and on dashboard
- Looks at other options - would prefer not to hide the mailing options in the accordion - some people don't like using CC online and may not click to see more options

Are users able to understand what forms to complete for each document, and how and where to upload those documents?

Dashboard: Form Instructions

- When asked How would you fill out the PDF form; Looking for something that says “i owe but not the amount the IRS says”
- Expects the checkboxes to work - this is not an interactive webpage
- If he can’t edit it on his phone, he isn’t expecting to be able to edit it on his computer - would just save it and print it
- 99% of people probably check Notice of Deficiency - he would expect that a bunch of people fill this out incorrectly
- Kinda of intimidating
- Would you be able to take a picture of the notice to include it with the Petition (if completing the entire form by mobile phone)
- Opens the form PDFs ; Understands she would need to fill out the forms to be able to complete the Petition
- Ugh - gotta download a PDF and either have to do things in the PDF software or depending on the rules (does this require a wet signature) and then scan it?- that’s a pain in the butt
- Feels like - great i’ve downloaded this, and i’m filling it out , but unsure about what to do next
- Doesn’t like when there is another form she has to download, and then upload, wants juts one online form; “Don’t like it when there’s a form I have to open up, fill in and then upload. It would be nice if I could do it all in the online form.”
- ODS form asks for docket number-(Kim)
- Thinks the docket number is on the IRS Notice (Kim)
- could be confusing when asking them to upload this before the case has been started
- What to expect when filing a case, sees forms you need ; Able to download forms to tablet
- Wants to know do I need to print this info out
- On iphone, PDF doesn't appear to be fillable - how would mobile-only users be able to complete this ? Would end up emailing the PDF to himself , to complete it on a desktop/laptop
- Wouldn’t mind filling out the petition form on a phone; Thinks this is something he could fill out in one go - if it were an online form ; Typing a lot on mobile could be cumbersome, but may not be an issue; may be fighting auto-correct
- If he wasn’t sure about what to put in the form, he wouldn’t start it ; if he needed to contact an attorney, he would do that before beginning this process

Are users able to understand what forms to complete for each document, and how and where to upload those documents?

Dashboard: Form Instructions

- Expects 15 minutes to complete the Petition form by phone, if he was prepared
- Pretty clear to him that he needs to download the forms and fill them out to upload later
- Understands the ODS language
- Would like to be more do this and this
- Everyone will need to upload this to create a case - thinks no one is going to read that- gets lost in the text

Tips Screen: Form Instructions

- Language to download forms needs to be more directive
- Deadline makes sense ; STIN - checks the form to confirm that she had the right form; Understands that she needs the ODS as a business and has the form downloaded
- Wasn't sure if he had already downloaded these forms "they all have similar names"
- Understands easily that he must download, complete and then will re upload the forms

Step 1: STIN

- Asked at first if she needed to download the forms, but said it's clear that the STIN and Petition were the forms previously downloaded; A little confused about uploading document
- Glad that the link is there again
- Confirms the uploaded form is same form number as the one there to download
- Didn't realize these were the same forms - at first glance he thought, oh are these more forms i need to fill out; He read it and then understood
- Likes that it offers the STIN form download again - in case you hadn't done it
- Doesn't have this document - not sure what to upload; Assumes that they mailed it? Didn't notice the download - or if she did, she didn't realize that this form was something she needed to complete, thought these were forms that were provided to her; Has trouble with language ; Has trouble with what to do and downloads

Are users able to understand what forms to complete for each document, and how and where to upload those documents?

Step 2: Petition

- Would be helpful to see an example of a completed form
- Downloads the Petition form - keying in on the actions that she needs to take, basically ignoring the rest of the information
- Would prefer to see a literal direction "Download this form"; Download link seemed like another set of instructions - expected it to be a "help document"

Step 5: Review Your Petition

- Doesn't know whether or not she should sign the actual pdfs
- Doesn't know what the STIN is on this page - "might not remember what that is" ; Also concerned about giving out her SSN - concerned if this is part of public record, would question if she really wants to do this online
- Signature on pdf required?

General: Completing PDFs

- Has seen both ways, but mostly sees online forms that can just be completed as you go (inputting directly online) - thinks this would mitigate any problems of uploading the wrong form, etc.

Does the user understand when to redact their PII, and when to include it (STIN)?

Step 2 - Petition and Case Type / Redaction:

- Reads the redaction information - like that it tells you to actually redact not just put black triangles
- Redaction - thinks knowing why redacting is important would be good- info will be public record

Step 5 - Review Your Petition / Redaction:

- Notice about redacting the info is weird - well, don't ask for the STIN to begin with
- Removed or redacted, does that mean before i send this? Let's say that i didn't redact, i have to go back into each document to check and reupload if it wasn't redacted

Can the user easily complete the form wizard?

Step 2 - Petition and Case Type / Case Type Selection:

- Categories very hard to read on mobile
- If someone selected “No” for Notice -looks that it has more options, including the Other option in case you didn’t really know

Step 2 - Petition and Case Type / First Impressions:

- Doesn’t explicitly know what is required fields - will it let you move on without uploading a file; Sees error when trying to continue w/o petition- “That’s good to have”

Step 2 - Petition and Case Type / Error Prevention/Handling:

- Are all of these required? Fields. Missed the message at the top.

Step 3 - Parties / First Impressions:

- Name - expect it to say “legal name” or first name last name , or somehow be linked to what it would say on her tax records
- Party type - selects myself, straightforward ; Everything i would expect from govt website
- Would be handy to do it on the phone - wouldn’t have to type in the whole address- probably browser would autocomplete
- Expects that if he’s filing for himself the name and info should already be in the system from his profile
- Easily selects myself since it was a single person on notice

Can the user easily complete the form wizard? Continued:

Step 3 - Parties / Error Prevention/Handling:

- Would like to see a “required” next to required fields ;Sees the optional and doesn’t explicitly realize the others are required
- Didn’t read the all field required- questioned what was required, triggers error and understands

Step 3 - Parties / Copying Address to Spouse:

- Expects the “copy address” checkbox to uncheck when spouse’s info is updated
- Likes the checkbox for copying address to spouse
- Impressed with auto-fill

Step 4 - Case Procedure and Trial Location / Trial Location:

- Trial location- expected a jump to feature on dropdown (Peter)
- Had to calculate himself which location was closest

Step 5 - Review Your Petition / Editing Form:

- Easily able to navigate back to edit - yes everything is still selected!!
- Expects “edit” buttons directly to the selected information

Does the user understand that they need to merge the Petition and IRS Notice into a single PDF? Do they know how to accomplish this?

Tips

- Knows how to combine the Petition and Notice into one PDF - no problem with that
- Merging Petition and Notice - would be helpful to include on the dashboard - would be annoying to start and then have to go back and scan another PD
- Reads petition info; "OK did that"; Doesn't pay any attention to merging the Petition and Notice into one PDF
- Notices merging two PDFs into one PDF; That'd be nice; The more separate forms you submit, the more chances they'd be separated somehow - would prefer fewer files to track and fewer pieces that could go missing
- Doesn't know how to do this on a phone - doesn't know if Adobe Acrobat has a mobile version to do this
- Would probably have to leave the form here and go merge the PDFs on another device
- Petition - like that it has resource to be able to merge PDFs

Case Confirmation / Merging IRS Notice & Petition:

- When prompted, Said he did see a phrase about merging PDFs, but didn't pay much attention to it

How confident are users to submit their completed form to the Court?

Step 5 - Review Your Petition:

- Surprised that it's only collecting that little of information - but that's a good thing
- Where's my payment thing?"
- Sees PDF preview - I assume this is my uploaded file - "that's awesome"
- Likes to be able to view his inputs on the review screen as confirmation it accepted changes
- Confused by the numbering and labelling; My Cases - Create Case - Review Your Case
- You haven't really created the case yet but it's asking you to review it
- Maybe just change labelling
- Doesn't know what the STIN is on this page - "might not remember what that is" ; Also concerned about giving out her SSN - concerned if this is part of public record, would question if she really wants to do this online

Step 5 - Review Your Petition - Reminders

- Timeliness check - doesn't know immediately if the system will let her submit the petition even if it's not timely
- Didn't have any concerns - he's a skimming so he had to go back to double check what he skimmed

How confident are users to submit their completed form to the Court?

Progress Bar / Indicator:

- Likes the progress bar - takes a little longer than expected, sees 100% complete but it's still spinning
- Likes the progress indicator - good to know "something's happening"

Case Confirmation - Next Steps:

- Is confident and would use this system to file online
- Goes back to Dashboard - see that her case is there "So that's good" (Annette)
- Would like more confirmation/information after submit
- Highly confident that he has completed the petition process (once he has completed step 5 of 5, expects it be done - feel confident that he has completed every; not as confident around what the next steps are

What are user expectations after they submit the petition? Do they understand what will happen next?:

Case Confirmation / Next Steps:

- Wants to know whether she's "completed" the process; Unclear exactly what that means - she said she's heard things around the court that people think they've completed it but they haven't
- When am i gonna hear something; Once your petition is processed by the court - wants to know how long that process will take
- May be good to align with the initial steps from the dashboard - yes you've submitted the petition but you still haven't done what you need to move forward
- Expects to be "done" by the time she gets to the confirmation page
- Would take a screenshot to remember his docket number
- Expects an email confirmation - or something to tell him more information
- Sees but quickly clicks on the docket number and is navigated away to case detail
- Goes back to Dashboard - see that her case is there "So that's good" (Annette)
- Would like more confirmation/information after submit
- Understands she has a docket number; Reads all info here; Clicks back to Dashboard
- It "did make sense" - thinking she was going to a place where she could upload more documents or add any additional information, also pay the fee
- Does not know where to go from here

Dashboard / Accessing A Case:

- Would like to see if filing was completed

What are user expectations after they submit the petition? Do they understand what will happen next? Continued:

Dashboard / Next Steps:

- Would expect it on the confirmation page - to know what the next checkbox is for her to do
- Not sure what next steps are, action items
- Unsure if he's supposed to tell them when the trial is or if they tell him
- Prompted to click Case Information - this is what he was looking for; Wants action items to be more upfront
- Highly confident that he has completed the petition process (once he has completed step 5 of 5, expects it be done - feel confident that he has completed every; not as confident around what the next steps are
- Would expect a little flag or something to identify what actions need to be taken
- FAQs would be nice to have for additional information